

Boston Sunday Globe

Serving our community since 1872

JULY 20, 2025

Austerity aside, pet projects survive

Despite budget stress, lawmakers fund favorites

By Samantha J. Gross and Matt Stout
GLOBE STAFF

With fiscal uncertainty bubbling up from Washington, Massachusetts legislative leaders took action last month. They trimmed the state's spending plan by hundreds of millions of dollars, set aside cash to cushion a possible future fiscal blow, and even cut into programs that help the state's poorest amid "tight fiscal constraints."

What, by and large, they did not slash: money for their hand-picked projects.

Lawmakers included \$172 million in earmarks in the budget they delivered to Governor Maura Healey, devoting millions alone to towns, nonprofits, and programs inside Democratic leaders' districts, according to a Boston Globe analysis. When they did eliminate earmarked funds, it was often at the expense of a small band of rank-and-file Republicans who voted against the budget, according to a Globe review of the more than 1,100 earmarks and data compiled by the legislative tracking

EARMARKS, Page A12

Ming Fay's playful papier-mâché sculptures at the Gardner museum are balm for the wilted spirit. **N1.**

Take a look at small living spaces, from a slim build in Maine to a Danish design in Lexington. **Globe Magazine.**

A recent Harvard Business School graduate has sued the school, saying it discriminated against him because he is Jewish. **B1.**



Road trip with a mission

By day, Rolando Pujol is a journalist in New York, but the rest of the time, he's the Retrologist, a documentarian of midcentury roadside kitsch. **N12.**



Rumble; drier

Sunday: Stormy.
High: 85-90. Low: 65-70.
Monday: Sunny, drier.
High: 78-83. Low: 58-63.
Sunrise: 5:25 Sunset: 8:15
Complete report, **A22.**
Deaths, **A16-21.**

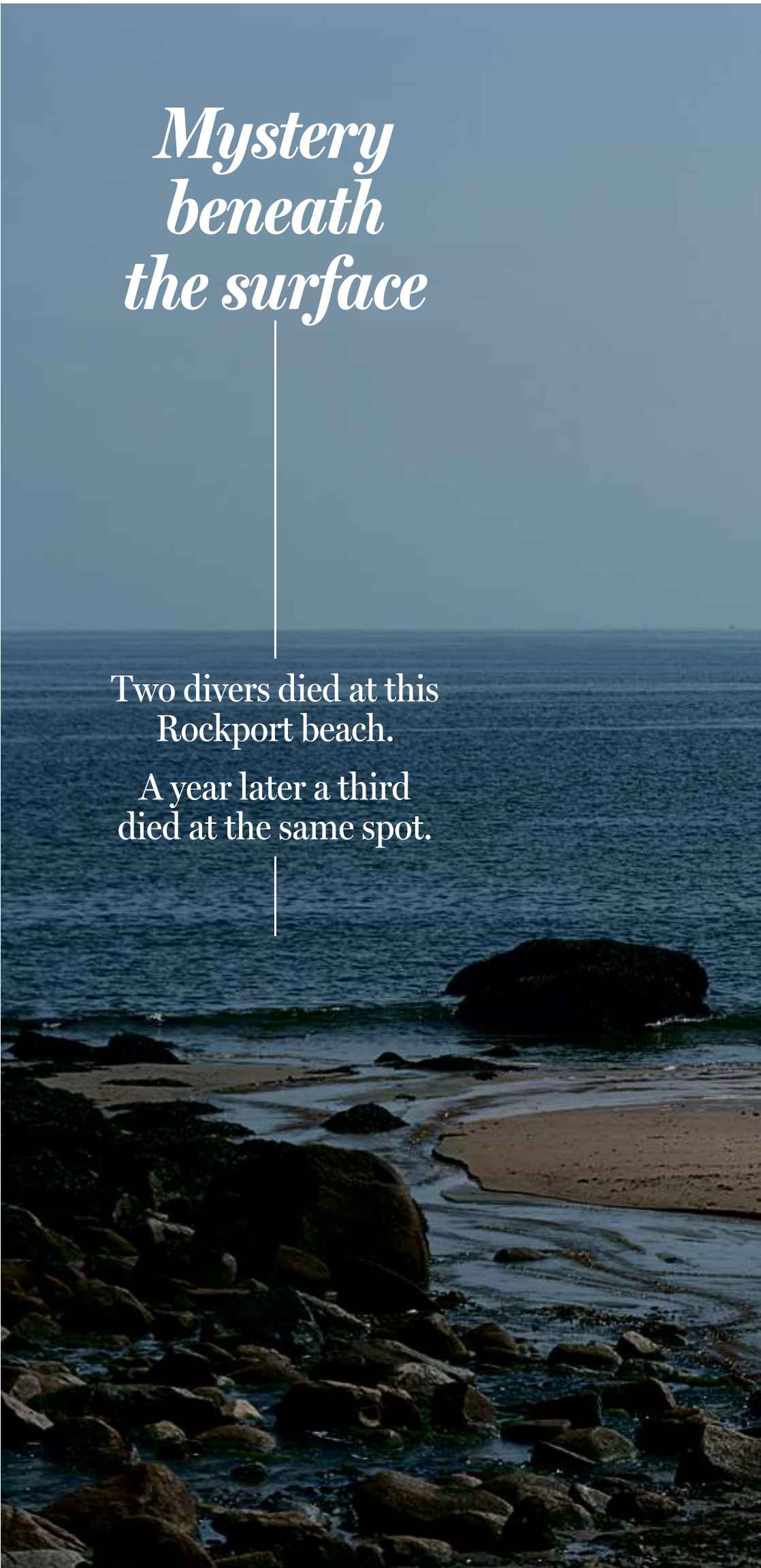
VOL. 308, NO. 20
*
Suggested retail price
\$6.00



Mystery beneath the surface

Two divers died at this Rockport beach.

A year later a third died at the same spot.



SUZANNE KREITER/GLOBE STAFF

In 2023, Richard Brady and Alan Leao died while scuba diving off Front Beach in Rockport.

Families, others haunted by eerie similarities between deaths of two diving buddies and a third victim

By Billy Baker
GLOBE STAFF

ROCKPORT — It was just after 11 a.m. on a perfect October day in 2023 when the body of a diver washed up on Front Beach.

It took police three hours to figure out the man was a 75-year-old from Pepperell named Alan Leao. That's when authorities discovered that Leao had not been diving alone.

And the other diver, his brother-in-law, was missing.

Just before 6 p.m., as the sun dipped low in the sky, their families stood on Front Beach and watched search boats slowly sweep a grid in front of them. When one of those boats stopped just offshore, they knew the second diver, 78-year-old Richard Brady, was dead, too.

Now they wanted to know why.
Why did two experienced divers, in shallow water at a sandy beach on a 72-degree day, with plenty of air left in their tanks, just die? What was the connection?

Visibly, there was nothing wrong with either man. Neither showed signs of an attack or an entanglement. The State Police divers who pulled Brady from the seafloor went through each man's gear and found nothing wrong with it.

When Brady's son, Bill, identified his body after it was returned to shore, he said "he looked almost peaceful."

Everyone believed there had to

be something wrong with their air. They must have gotten their tanks filled together and somehow carbon monoxide or some other contaminant had crept in. That's what the family and the harbor master and the State Police all assumed, as investigators waited late into the night for a state hazmat testing team to arrive from Amherst.

But the field test found nothing. The air looked as clean as what was in the tanks the rescue divers had just used.

Then what's the connection? That's the question that has haunted everyone involved.

Or perhaps it's the alternative that's done the most haunting.

DIVERS, Page A14

Oversight of homes for elders too light?

Push to regulate assisted living more as needs of residents intensify

By Jason Laughlin, Kay Lazar, and Shelley Murphy
GLOBE STAFF

Kathleen Lynch Moncata learned the limitations of assisted living the hard way: through a catastrophe involving a relative.

A decade ago, her mother-in-law, Rose Moncata, fell in the middle of the night at an assisted living facility in the Metro West area. A young aide who was supposed to check during the night had merely popped her head through the doorway, but didn't turn on the light or enter the room, where the 91-year-old woman lay on the floor with a broken neck.

► **A 10th person has died after the Fall River fire. B3.**

Kathleen Lynch Moncata, an attorney who specializes in elder law, said her mother-in-law lay there for hours until the morning shift came in and discovered her. She died four days later.

"Even as an attorney, I didn't really understand what assisted living was until my own parents lived there," said Moncata, who switched her law practice to focus on elder issues after her parents became assisted living residents. **ASSISTED LIVING, Page A13**

ASSISTED LIVING FACILITIES

A housing option for seniors who want autonomy and need help with daily activities but not intensive medical care. They have fewer medical staff and are less regulated.

SKILLED NURSING HOMES

Residents must have higher medical needs, while facilities must have certain levels of trained staff and provide more intensive care. They are more closely regulated but typically have a more restrictive environment for residents.

The AI shrink will compute for you now

More popular, chatbot therapy raises concerns

By Alexa Gagosz
GLOBE STAFF

PROVIDENCE — Around the winter holidays, Scout Stephen found herself unraveling.

She desperately needed to speak to someone. She reached out to her therapist, but they were on vacation. Her friends were unavailable. She tried calling a suicide crisis hot line, but it felt robotic and left her feeling more alone and disconnected.

Frantic and on edge, Stephen turned to ChatGPT for help. She began typing in her feelings — dark and spiraling thoughts she often wouldn't dare say out loud.

The AI bot didn't respond with generic advice but with something that felt to her like empathy. It asked questions and reflected the pain she was feeling back to her in a way that felt human, that made her feel heard.

"It was my last resort that day," said Stephen, 26, of Providence. "Now, it's my first go-to."

With the mental health care system overburdened and millions of Americans unable to access it, **AI, Page A9**



SUZANNE KREITER/GLOBE STAFF

Scout Stephen of Providence said using ChatGPT for therapy has literally been a lifesaver for her.